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Muzaffarnagar is a ramshackle, crowded town in western UP, about 127 kilometres from the national capital. With its broken roads, unruly traffic and scores of young men just loitering around, Muzaffarnagar typifies the gradual decline of UP. It is also in the heart of the state's sugar belt and is a bit like the Wild West with a thriving business in unlicensed guns. A friend of mine who worked in a sugar company used to travel to his Muzaffarnagar factory with armed guards. 'You could take no chances, especially at night, in the town,' is what he told me.

Politically, this had been Chaudhary Charan Singh country. The former prime minister had built a social compact between his fellow landowning Jats and the local Muslims, many of whom were artisans and agricultural labourers. It had been a relationship based on shared economic interest which had endured for the most part. Travelling with Ajit Singh on the campaign trail in the 1990s, I was struck by the reverence people had for his father. '*Chaudhary sahib sabko*

saath lete hain, Jat ho ya Muslim' (Chaudhury sahib takes everyone along with him, Jat or Muslim), was the near-unanimous refrain.

But in August 2013, that delicately woven social alliance collapsed. Jats and Muslims found themselves engaged in a bloody communal riot that lasted several days and left sixty-two persons dead, with more than 50,000 persons displaced. The riots, worryingly, engulfed Muzaffarnagar's villages which had been relatively immune to religious tension. No one is quite sure what sparked off the violence. The police FIR claimed there had been a bike accident which led to a fight in which two Hindus and one Muslim boy were killed. Others (mainly the Hindu Jats) claimed that there was an eve-teasing incident that triggered the conflict.

I must honestly confess that no national news channel gave the story adequate coverage, initially. Death in the age of breaking news can often be reduced to a statistic—three people killed in what appeared a localized clash didn't seem to shake the media into action. It was only in the first